

- **Associate with people from different cultures.** Learn about other cultures to widen your knowledge and tolerance of intercultural nonverbal messages.
- **Appreciate the power of appearance.** Keep in mind that the appearance of your business documents, your business space, and yourself sends immediate positive or negative messages to others.
- **Observe yourself on video.** Ensure that your verbal and nonverbal messages are in sync by recording and evaluating yourself making a presentation.
- **Enlist friends and family.** Ask friends and family members to monitor your conscious and unconscious body movements and gestures to help you become a more effective communicator.

1-4 Understanding Culture and Communication

LEARNING OUTCOME 4

Describe the key dimensions of culture and how technology and social media shape intercultural communication.

Even when communicators share the same culture, comprehending the verbal and nonverbal meanings of a message can be difficult. When different cultures come together, special sensitivity and skills are necessary. Global business, communication technologies, and social media span the world, reducing distances. However, cultural differences persist in the increasingly multiethnic United States—and can cause significant misunderstandings.

Defining Culture. For our purposes, **culture** may be defined as the complex system of values, traits, morals, and customs shared by a society. Culture is a powerful operating force that molds the way we think, behave, and communicate. The objective of this section is to broaden your view of culture and open your mind to flexible attitudes so that you can avoid frustration when cultural adjustment is necessary. Globalization, growing diversity, and social networking demand that we adjust and adopt new attitudes.

To help you better understand your culture and how it contrasts with other cultures, we describe five key dimensions of culture: context, individualism, time orientation, power distance, and communication style. The section closes with a look at the interaction between culture and social media.

1-4a High and Low Context

Context is probably the most important cultural dimension and also the most difficult to define. In a model developed by cultural anthropologist Edward T. Hall, context refers to the stimuli, environment, or ambience surrounding an event. Hall arranged cultures on a continuum, shown in **Figure 1.5**, from low to high in relation to context.¹⁵ This figure also summarizes key comparisons for today's business communicators.

Communicators in low-context cultures (such as those in North America, Scandinavia, and Germany) depend little on the context of a situation and shared experience to convey their meaning. They assume that messages must be explicit, and listeners rely exclusively on the written or spoken word. Low-context cultures tend to be linear, analytical, and action oriented. Business communicators stress clearly articulated messages that they consider to be objective, professional, and efficient. Words are taken literally.

Communicators in high-context cultures (such as those in China, Japan, and Middle Eastern countries) assume that the listener does not need much background information.¹⁶ High-context cultures are more likely to be intuitive and contemplative. Communicators in these cultures pay attention to more than the spoken or written word. They emphasize interpersonal relationships, nonverbal expression, physical settings, and social context. For example, Japanese communicators might say yes when they really mean no. From the context of the situation, the Japanese speaker would

Figure 1.5 Comparing Low- and High-Context Cultures

Culture has a powerful effect on business communicators. The following observations point out selected differences. However, these are simplifications, and practices within a given culture vary considerably. Moreover, as globalization expands, low- and high-context cultures are experiencing change, and differences may be less pronounced.



indicate whether yes really meant yes or whether it meant no. The context, tone, time taken to answer, facial expression, and body cues would convey the meaning of yes.²⁷ Thus, in high-context cultures, communication cues tend to be transmitted by posture, voice inflection, gestures, and facial expression.

1-4b Individualism and Collectivism

An attitude of independence and freedom from control characterizes **individualism**. Members of low-context cultures, particularly North Americans, tend to value individualism. They believe that initiative and self-assertion result in personal achievement. They believe in individual action and personal responsibility, and they desire much freedom in their personal lives.

Members of high-context cultures are more **collectivist**. They emphasize membership in organizations, groups, and teams; they encourage acceptance of group values, duties, and decisions. They typically resist independence because it fosters competition and confrontation instead of consensus. In group-oriented cultures, such as those in many Asian societies, self-assertion and individual decision making are discouraged. "The nail that sticks up gets pounded down" is a common Japanese saying.²⁸ Business decisions are often made by all who have competence in the matter under discussion. Similarly, in China managers also focus on the group rather than on the individual, preferring a consultative management style over an autocratic style.²⁹

Cultures are complex, of course, and cannot be characterized as totally individualistic or group oriented. To complicate things, group differences may be lessening over time. For example, Americans of European descent are generally quite individualistic, whereas African Americans are less so, and Americans with a Latinx or Hispanic heritage are closer to the group-centered dimension. Newer research suggests **cultural convergence**, a trend toward greater global similarity particularly in higher individualism and lower power distance.⁶⁰ **Figure 1.6** shows selected countries ranked according to their expression of collectivism and individualism as well as power distance.

1-4c Time Orientation

The perception of time and its use are culturally learned. In some cultures, time is perceived sequentially. North Americans, for example, tend to consider time a precious commodity. They correlate time with productivity, efficiency, and money. Keeping people waiting for business appointments is considered a waste of time and rude. E. T. Hall called this time orientation **monochronic time** or *M-Time*, that is, time perceived as if it were running on a single, linear track.

In other cultures (e.g., most Asian, South American, and Native American), time may be perceived as an unlimited resource to be enjoyed; it is open and flexible. This is defined by Hall as **polychronic time** or *P-Time*. Time is viewed as abundant and nonlinear. Relationships are more important than tasks. People in monochronic Western cultures may schedule appointments at 15- to 30-minute intervals. Businesspeople in polychronic cultures may plan fewer but longer meetings without a defined end time. People in monochronic cultures may look at time as formal and task oriented. In polychronic cultures, time is seen as an opportunity to develop interpersonal relationships.

A group of North American businesspeople, for example, was kept waiting two hours past a scheduled appointment time in South America. The executives weren't

Figure 1.6 Selected Countries' Ranking in Collectivism, Individualism, and Power Distance



offended, though, because they were familiar with South Americans' more polychronic concept of time. When it comes to attitudes toward time, again, cultures are complex and cannot be neatly divided into monochronic or polychronic. In some countries both tendencies may coexist.

1-4d Power Distance

One important element of culture is **power distance**, which was first introduced by influential social psychologist Geert Hofstede. The Power Distance Index measures how people in different societies cope with inequality—in other words, how they relate to more powerful individuals. In high-power-distance countries, subordinates expect formal hierarchies and embrace relatively authoritarian, paternalistic power relationships. In low-power-distance cultures, however, subordinates consider themselves as equals of their supervisors. They confidently voice opinions and participate in decision making. Relationships between high-powered individuals and people with little power tend to be more democratic, egalitarian, and informal.

As you have probably guessed, in most Western cultures people are more relaxed about social status and the appearance of power.⁴¹ Deference is not generally paid to individuals merely because of their wealth, position, seniority, or age. In many Asian cultures, however, these characteristics are important. A strict top-down management structure allows for faster decision making, but it also prevents subordinates from speaking up due to fear or resignation, researchers say. Employee silence can be costly. For example, it has been blamed for such disasters as the Sanlu milk powder scandal in China and the Fukushima nuclear power plant explosion in Japan.⁴² The degree of power distance in selected countries is illustrated in Figure 1.6.

1-4e Communication Style

People in low- and high-context cultures tend to communicate differently with words. To Americans and Germans, for example, words are very important, especially in contracts and negotiations. People in high-context cultures, on the other hand, place more emphasis on the surrounding context than on the words describing a negotiation. Greek businesspeople may see a contract as a formal statement announcing the intention to build a business for the future. The Japanese may treat contracts as statements of intention, and they assume changes will be made as projects develop. Mexican managers may perceive contracts as approximations of what might be accomplished in an ideal world. They do not necessarily expect contracts to apply consistently in the real world. Some Arab cultures may be insulted by the mere mention of a contract; a person's word is more binding.⁴³

In communication style North Americans value straightforwardness, are suspicious of evasiveness, and distrust people whom they perceive as having a hidden agenda or playing their cards too close to the chest.⁴⁴ North Americans also tend to be uncomfortable with silence and impatient with delays. Some Asian businesspeople have learned that the longer they drag out negotiations, the more concessions impatient North Americans are likely to make.

1-4f Technology and Social Media Affect Intercultural Communication

Few would question the connectedness and networking provided by social media and communication technology today. With minimal resources, communicators can interact instantly across vast distances with larger and more varied audiences than ever before. Not surprisingly, social media may potentially bridge cultural differences or reinforce them, depending on their users.



Social Media: Blurring Boundaries? What we make of the potential for positive intercultural connectedness online is as much up to us as it would be at a dinner party where we don't know any of the other guests. Some authors believe that social media used **mindfully** can benefit mental health, blur cultural gaps, reduce hierarchies, and empower people to change their circumstances.⁴⁵ At the same time, the online environment may deepen feelings of social isolation, leading to depression and the much debated **loneliness epidemic**, only made worse by the COVID-19 pandemic.⁴⁶

Online, as in real life, we gravitate toward people who seem like us, believes social entrepreneur Rajiv Vinnakota. Social media divide us because we inhabit “echo chambers” online instead of “bridging social capital” and interacting with people not like us as we used to do offline, he says.⁴⁷ However, shared causes can mobilize social media users halfway across the globe—for example, the international climate movement Friday for Future or the pro-democracy student protesters in Hong Kong—as they try to win the hearts and minds of the public.⁴⁸

Whether social media networks will allow business communicators to engage across cultures and bridge intercultural differences will depend on the users’ attitudes and openness.

Social Media: Global and Local? Despite cultural convergence—the equalizing influence of globalization on cultures around the world—regional and cultural differences persist, as those who design media for markets in other countries know. Adobe Inc., for example, is represented by 30 corporate websites that are adapted to local country-specific tastes and expectations.

Knowledge of color symbolism across cultures is indispensable for designers lest they commit cultural blunders. Consider that **yellow**—a hue with generally positive connotations in Western cultures, but one that also represents cowardice—stands for courage in Japan. Orange, the signature color of the Dutch royal court, epitomizes the harvest and fall in North America and Europe. Likewise, in Asia, orange is an auspicious hue; however, in the Middle East, orange signifies mourning and loss.⁴⁹

More serious differences nationally as well as globally are now caused by geopolitical turmoil, cyberattacks by foreign powers, and restricted access to the Internet in authoritarian countries around the world—a trend that has been called **digital nationalism**. Some predictions foresee a so-called **Splinternet**, a fragmentation of the Internet, once viewed as a unified global network.⁵⁰ It remains to be seen whether the deep divides will dissipate or continue to grow.

LEARNING OUTCOME 5

Identify strategies for enhancing intercultural effectiveness and communication across cultures.

1-5 Ensuring Intercultural Effectiveness

Being aware of your own culture and how it contrasts with others is a first step in learning intercultural skills. Another step involves recognizing barriers to intercultural accommodation and striving to overcome them. The digital age economy needs workers who can thrive on diverse teams and interact effectively with customers and clients at home and abroad. This section addresses how to overcome barriers to productive intercultural communication, develop strong intercultural skills, and capitalize on workplace diversity.

1-5a Avoiding Ethnocentrism and Stereotyping

The process of understanding and interacting successfully with people from other cultures is often hampered by two barriers: ethnocentrism and stereotyping. These barriers, however, can be overcome by developing tolerance and empathy, two powerful and effective aids to communication.

Ethnocentrism. The belief in the superiority of one's own ethnic group is known as **ethnocentrism**, an attitude found in all cultures. Ethnocentrism causes us to judge others by our own values. If you were raised in North America, values such as punctuality and directness probably seem right to you, and you may wonder why the rest of the world doesn't function in the same "sensible" fashion. A North American businessperson in an Arab or Asian country might be upset at time spent over coffee or other social rituals before any real business is transacted. In these cultures, however, personal relationships must be established and nurtured before negotiations may proceed.

Stereotypes. Our perceptions of other cultures sometimes cause us to form stereotypes about groups of people. A **stereotype** is an oversimplified, rigid perception of a behavioral pattern or characteristic applied uncritically to groups. For example, the Swiss are hardworking, efficient, and neat; Germans are formal, reserved, and blunt; Americans are loud, friendly, and impatient; Asians are gracious, humble, and inscrutable. These attitudes may or may not accurately describe cultural norms. When applied to individual business communicators, however, such stereotypes may be hurtful and cause misunderstandings. Look beyond superficial labels to discover individuals' unique qualities.

Tolerance and Open-Mindedness. As global markets expand and as our society becomes increasingly multiethnic, mutual tolerance is critical. **Tolerance** here means learning about those who are not like us; it means being open-minded and receptive to new experiences. With greater knowledge, patience, and compassion, tolerance may lead to understanding and acceptance.⁷² One of the best ways to become tolerant is to practice **empathy**, defined as trying to see the world through another's eyes. It means being less judgmental and more eager to seek common ground.

One way of promoting greater understanding is to work toward a common goal. An environmental studies center in Israel brings together Jews, Muslims, and Christians to tackle water scarcity in the Middle East, home to 10 of the 15 most water-starved countries in the world. The diverse student body is Jewish Israeli, Arab, and non-Middle Eastern. Aside from caring for the environment, the students attend peace-building forums to discuss race, religion, culture, and politics. The center develops one of the region's scarcest resources—trust.⁷³

Getting along with others is always a good policy, but doubly so in the workplace. Frequently job descriptions include statements such as *Must be able to communicate with diverse audiences*. The suggestions in the following section can help you prevent miscommunication in oral and written interactions across cultures.

1-5b Successful Oral Communication With Intercultural Audiences

When you have a conversation with someone from another culture, you can reduce misunderstandings by following these tips:

- **Use simple English.** Speak in short sentences (under 20 words) with familiar, short words. Eliminate puns, sport and military references, slang, and jargon (special business terms). Be especially alert to idiomatic expressions that can't be translated, such as *face the music* and *hit a home run*.
- **Speak slowly and enunciate clearly.** Avoid fast speech, but don't raise your voice. Overpunctuate with pauses and full stops. Always write and display numbers for all to see.
- **Encourage accurate feedback.** Ask probing questions, and encourage the listener to paraphrase what you say. Don't assume that a yes, a nod, or a smile indicates comprehension.



"[E]mployers are looking for people who have experienced the world and can bring a global perspective helping us to recognize our common engineering challenges and find solutions together. One way I have become a global citizen is through 'vol-untourism.' The term describes trips encompassing both volunteer work and tourism."⁷⁴

Rebecca Delaney,
engineering team leader,
associate director, Skidmore,
Owings & Merrill

- **Check frequently for comprehension.** Avoid waiting until you finish a long explanation to request feedback. Instead, make one point at a time and pause.
- **Observe eye messages.** Be alert to a glazed expression or wandering eyes. These tell you the listener is lost.
- **Accept blame.** If a misunderstanding results, graciously take responsibility for not making your meaning clear.
- **Listen without interrupting.** Curb your desire to finish sentences or to fill out ideas for the speaker. Keep in mind that North Americans abroad are often accused of listening too little and talking too much.
- **Smile when appropriate.** The smile is often considered the single most understood and most useful form of communication. In some cultures, however, excessive smiling may seem insincere.
- **Follow up in writing.** After conversations or oral negotiations, confirm the results and agreements with written messages. For proposals and contracts, hire a professional translator.

1-5c Successful Written Communication With Intercultural Audiences

When you write to someone from a different culture, you can improve your chances of being understood by following the following suggestions:

- **Consider local styles and conventions.** Learn how documents are formatted and how letters are addressed and developed in the intended reader's country. Decide whether to use your organization's preferred format or adjust to local styles.
- **Observe titles and rank.** Use last names, titles, and other signals of rank and status. Send messages to higher-status people; avoid sending copies to lower-rank people.
- **Hire a translator.** Engage a professional translator if (a) your document is important, (b) your document will be distributed to many readers, or (c) you must be persuasive.
- **Use short sentences and short paragraphs.** Sentences with fewer than 20 words and paragraphs with fewer than 8 lines are most readable.
- **Avoid ambiguity.** Include relative pronouns (that, which, who) for clarity in introducing clauses. Stay away from contractions (especially ones such as *Here's the problem*). Replace two-word verbs with clear single words (return instead of bring back; delay instead of put off; maintain instead of keep up). Avoid idioms (once in a blue moon), slang (my presentation really bombed), acronyms (ASAP for as soon as possible), abbreviations (DBA for doing business as), jargon (input, bottom line), and sports references (ballpark figure, slam dunk). Use action-specific verbs (buy a printer rather than get a printer).
- **Cite numbers carefully.** In international trade most nations use the metric system. In citing numbers, use figures (12) instead of spelling them out (twelve). Always convert dollar figures into local currency. Spell out the month when writing dates. In North America, for example, March 5, 2022, might be written as 3/5/2022, whereas in Europe the same date might appear as 5.3.2022.

1-5d Growing Workforce Diversity

While North American companies are expanding global operations and adapting to a variety of emerging markets, the domestic workforce is also becoming more diverse. This diversity has many dimensions—race, ethnicity, age, religion, gender, national

origin, disability, sexual orientation, and others. No longer, say the experts, will the workplace be predominantly Anglo-oriented or male-centered.

Today, people of color (individuals with African, Latinx or Hispanic, Asian, or Native American heritage) already comprise 39 percent of the U.S. population. New projections indicate that 2045 will be the year when communities of color will represent the majority of the U.S. population at 50.3 percent.⁷⁴ Women comprise nearly 50 percent of the workforce. Moreover, the share of the population over 65 will jump from 15 percent now to almost 22 percent in 2050. By 2030 one in five residents will have reached retirement age, outnumbering children for the first time in U.S. history.⁷⁵ Many of these older people will remain in the workforce. Thanks to technological advances, more disabled individuals are also joining the workforce.

What do all these changes mean for you? Simply put, your job may require you to interact with coworkers and customers from around the world. You will need to cooperate with individuals and teams. What's more, your coworkers may differ from you in race, ethnicity, gender, age, and other ways.

1-5e Understanding the Benefits of Diversity at Work

As society and the workforce become more diverse, successful communication among the various identity groups brings distinct advantages in three areas.

Consumers. Consumers want to deal with companies that respect their values and look like them. A diverse staff is better able to respond to the increasingly diverse customer base in local and world markets. The CEO of a PR firm embraces a diverse staff and customers: "Our team consists of more than 40 people who collectively speak 20 different languages." A CEO in PR urges fellow executives to "Tap into the diversity of your workplace to gain a deep understanding of your workforce and your potential customer base."⁷⁶

Work Teams. Leadership experts agree that diversity enhances creativity because inclusive teams bring novel perspectives to the table, resulting in better decision making and problem solving. One leadership consultant says that a culturally diverse group "can create an esprit de corps" and "a feeling of camaraderie among team members" resulting in successful cooperation. Aside from creativity and cohesion, diverse teams are 45 percent more likely to increase market share and 70 percent more likely to capture a new market.⁷⁸

Businesses. Organizations gradually realize that inclusivity is a critical bottom-line strategy to increase revenue, engage employees, and spur innovation. A McKinsey report found that gender and ethnically diverse executive teams were 33 percent more likely to lead their industry in profitability.⁷⁹ Researchers say that inclusion not only makes business sense but also benefits all workers. "The best workplaces forge bonds among co-workers of different political views, different backgrounds, different job titles," says Ann Nadeau, chief people officer at Great Place to Work.⁸⁰

Developing a diverse staff that can work together cooperatively is one of the biggest challenges and opportunities facing business organizations today.

1-5f Communicating in a Diverse Workplace

Acceptance and harmony do not happen automatically when dissimilar people work together. This means that organizations must commit to diversity. Harnessed effectively, diversity and inclusion can enhance productivity and propel a company to success. Mismanaged, it can become a drain on a company's resources. How companies deal with diversity will make all the difference in how they compete in a technology-driven global environment. The following suggestions can help you find ways to improve communication and interaction.

- **Seek training.** Especially if an organization is experiencing diversity problems, awareness-raising sessions or training programs may be helpful. Spend time learning



"Everyone can and should be adept at interacting with people from other cultures. Do research. Be curious. Don't make assumptions. For organizations, diversity works when there is commitment from the top, education programs and appointments made of people who are experienced at managing change across cultures."⁷⁴

Johann Xavier, managing partner, OZ advisory Inc., Canada

about workforce diversity and how it can benefit organizations. Look upon diversity and inclusion as opportunities, not threats. Intercultural communication, team building, and conflict resolution are skills that can be learned.

- **Understand the value of difference.** Diversity makes an organization innovative and creative. Sameness fosters an absence of critical thinking called **groupthink**. Diversity can be a powerful antidote. Some researchers believe that if Wall Street had been more diverse, the financial crisis of 2008 could have been less severe.⁸¹ Economist and banker Mark Carney concurs: "Almost all decisions in finance are taken under uncertainty, making it especially important that decision makers are exposed to a range of views and engage in open debates with people whose perspectives challenge the prevailing wisdom."⁸²
- **Learn about your cultural self.** Begin to think of yourself as a product of your culture, and understand that your culture is just one among many. Take any opportunity to travel or study abroad, if possible. You will learn much, not only about other cultures but also about your own. Try to look at yourself from the outside. Do you see any reflex reactions and automatic thought patterns that are a result of your upbringing? These may be invisible to you until challenged by difference. Be sure to keep what works and yet be ready to adapt as environments change. Flexibility is an important survival skill.
- **Make fewer assumptions.** Be careful of seemingly insignificant, innocent workplace assumptions. For example, don't assume that everyone wants to observe the holidays with a Christmas party and a decorated tree. Celebrating only Christian holidays in December, January, and February excludes those who honor Hanukkah, Kwanzaa, Yule, and the Lunar New Year. Moreover, in workplace discussions don't assume anything about others' sexual orientations or attitudes toward marriage. For invitations, avoid phrases such as managers and their wives. Spouses or partners is inclusive. Valuing diversity means making fewer assumptions that everyone is like you or wants to be like you.
- **Build on similarities.** Look for areas in which you and others not like you can agree or at least share opinions. Be prepared to consider issues from many perspectives, all of which may be valid. Accept that there is room for various points of view to coexist peacefully. Although you can always find differences, it can be harder to find similarities. Look for common ground in shared experiences, mutual goals, and similar values.⁸³ Concentrate on your objective even when you may disagree on how to reach it.

Summary of Learning Outcomes

1 Describe how communication skills fuel career success in a challenging digital age marketplace.

- In an era of automation, augmented reality, and artificial intelligence, communication and other interpersonal skills can future-proof well-trained workers.
- Workers communicate more than ever; many collaborate in teams, which means that even technical fields require excellent communication skills.
- Employers expect new hires and other employees to project a professional image and possess superior interpersonal skills, including oral and written communication.
- Information age job challenges include rapid technological change and uncertainty, 24/7 availability, flatter management, an emphasis on teams, global competition, and a renewed focus on ethics.

2 Use active listening techniques.

- Organizational success and careers greatly depend on active listening, but most of us are poor listeners; to improve, we can remove physical and psychological barriers, overlook language problems, ignore nonverbal distractions, and curb our thought speed.
- A significant lag in language processing speed, called speech-thought differential, allows us to let our minds wander; as a result, we fake attention and prefer to talk rather than to listen.
- We can improve listening skills if we stop talking, focus fully on others, limit noise, adopt an empathic attitude, and distinguish facts from opinions.
- Capitalizing on lag time, listening for feelings and validating them, taking selective notes, and providing encouraging feedback are other methods for building listening skills.

3 Discuss how effective nonverbal communication can help you build your credibility and advance your career.

- Study nonverbal cues such as eye contact, facial expression, and posture that send silent, highly believable messages.
- Understand that how you use time, space, and territory is interpreted by the receiver, who also reads the eye appeal of your business documents and your personal appearance.
- Master nonverbal skills by keeping eye contact, using posture to signal interest, reducing physical barriers, improving your decoding skills, and probing for more information.
- Interpret nonverbal meanings in context, learn about other cultures, and consider the impact of appearance—of documents, your office space, and yourself.

4 Describe the key dimensions of culture and how technology and social media shape intercultural communication.

- Culture is a complex system of values, traits, ethics, and customs shared by a society; culture molds the way we think, behave, and communicate both offline and online.
- Culture can be described using key dimensions such as context, individualism, time orientation, power distance, and communication style.
- Today's communicators need to be aware of low- and high-context cultures, individualistic versus collectivist societies, differing attitudes toward time, clashing perceptions of power, and varying degrees of reliance on the written word.
- Whether social media can bridge cultural divides and erase differences or will lead to greater isolation will depend on the users as much as it would among strangers who meet at a dinner party.

5 Identify strategies for enhancing intercultural effectiveness and communication across cultures.

- Beware of ethnocentrism and stereotyping; instead, embrace tolerance and keep an open mind.
- In oral communication, use simple English, speak distinctly, check for comprehension, observe eye messages, accept responsibility for miscommunication, smile when appropriate, don't interrupt, and follow up in writing.
- When writing, consider local styles and conventions, hire a translator, use short sentences, avoid ambiguous wording, and cite numbers carefully.
- As the domestic workforce becomes more diverse, appreciate diversity as a critical business strategy.
- To communicate well with diverse audiences, seek training, understand the value of diversity, learn about your own culture, make fewer assumptions, and look for similarities.

Key Terms

soft skills 4
people skills 4
emotional intelligence 4
interpersonal skills 4
professional skills 4
sharing economy 7

smartphone apps 7
ad hoc teams 10
gig economy 10
empathic listening 10
mindful 10
speech-thought differential 11

nonverbal communication 12
culture 16
context 16
individualism 17
collectivist 17
cultural convergence 18